

Emerging issues associated with HIV patients seeking advice from health food stores.



OBJECTIVES: To ascertain the recommendations, training and education of health food store employees and determine how they communicate the costs, benefits and risks associated with natural health products for the HIV/AIDS community. METHODS: Four male research assistants, posing as asymptomatic HIV-positive individuals, inquired of employees of all retail health food stores in a major Canadian city as to what is recommended for their condition. The research assistants asked about product costs, side effects, potential drug interactions and efficacy. They also inquired as to employee education related to Complementary and Alternative Medicine (CAM) and noted whether employees asked about which conventional medications they were taking and whether they recommended that the subjects seek physician or CAM provider advice. RESULTS: A total of 32 stores were included. Eight store employees (25%) offered no advice; eight (25%) inquired whether the subjects were currently taking medications; six (19%) suggested visiting a physician; and eight (25%) suggested visiting a CAM provider. A total of 36 different products (mean 2.3 per employee) were recommended with considerable variability in product evidence and cost. The education of the employees varied from postgraduate education (n=3), to undergraduate degree (n=3), college level (n=5) in CAM, or no formal education in CAM (n=21). CONCLUSION: There was considerable heterogeneity in advice on natural food products provided by employees of natural food stores and, in general, these individuals had limited formal training in CAM. The products they recommended had limited evidence supporting their efficacy and in some instances were potentially harmful and had considerable costs. The findings of this study support the need to further examine how best to regulate this growing component of the health care system.